Freedom Is Not Enough

THE OPENING OF THE AMERICAN WORKPLACE

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The Rightness of Whiteness

THE CULTURE OF EXCLUSION organized life in the United States in the early 1950s so thoroughly that it appeared natural and unremarkable to nearly all white Americans. "You don't have to look for it to see it," recalled one black paper mill worker. "It was all right in front of you."[1] Although that culture's operations were most visible in the South, where segregation was enforced by law, by custom, and ultimately by violence, it defined all regions of the country. It drew strength from three institutions that together shaped much of twentieth-century American life: the family wage system, the sharecropping system, and the system of immigration restriction. The family wage shored up the place of white men as household breadwinners and the citizens at the center of public life, as it consigned to secondary status not only white female earners but also most men and women of color. Sharecropping undergirded the entire system of segregation and disfranchisement that kept black Americans veritable outsiders in a land in which they had deeper roots than most white Americans. The system of racially driven immigration restriction limited Mexican Americans' and Asian Americans' access to good jobs and, in different ways, undermined their standing as citizens.[2]

Those who upheld exclusion did so in keeping with traditions going back to the nation's founding. "American law," as the political scientist Rogers Smith noted, summing up decades of scholarship, has "long

been shot through with forms of second-class citizenship, denying personal liberties and opportunities for political participation to most of the adult population on the basis of race, ethnicity, gender, and even religion." These forms of inferior citizenship existed within the liberal and republican traditions on which Americans have prided themselves. Often, exclusion seemed so powerful as to be an independent third strain, expressed in "passionate beliefs that America was by rights a white nation, a Protestant nation, a nation in which true Americans were native-born men with Anglo-Saxon ancestors." The Constitution itself expressed the fusion: while granting novel self-rule to the white male citizenry, the nation's founding charter decreed that each slave would be counted as three fifths of a human being in determining taxation and representation. Congress "in its first words on the subject of citizenship . . . restricted naturalization to 'white persons,'" as one legal scholar reminds us, a "racial prerequisite to citizenship" not removed until 1952. As a result, for nearly all of its history, a majority of the country's adult inhabitants faced second-class treatment: African Americans, seen first as slaves, then as racial inferiors; Mexican Americans, seen as conquered peoples of the Southwest or illegal immigrants; Asian Americans, seen as "aliens" unfit to assimilate; women, seen as wives and daughters dependent on men; even for a long time Jews and Catholics, seen as outsiders in a culture defined by Protestant Christianity. All found themselves denied full access to rights, opportunities, and recognition in the mainstream economy and polity.[3]

Protected by laws and courts, embedded in the labor force, entrenched through unequal schooling, perpetuated through time-honored everyday practices, and sanctioned by prevailing thinking, the culture of exclusion was a powerful edifice. Its sheer mass deterred most would-be challengers. Yet the appearance of calm that prevailed in the 1950s belied the shifts occurring beneath the surface of a system whose foundations were frailer than ever before.

THE MAINSTREAM CULTURE of the era sent the message that white men—at least some white men—mattered more than other residents; they belonged in the best jobs and in positions of authority, for they were the real Americans. That culture decreed that what seemed to others to be obstacles to their progress were not in fact obstacles at all but rather evidence of their own unfitness for the positions they de-

sired. Nothing exhibited the underlying assumptions better than the popular imagery of the era. The family was the centerpiece of American mass culture in the mid-1950s and its proudest apostle to the wider world. Always, the lifestyles of abundance that rising real wages—family wages, as they came to be known—afforded such families served as the foundation of their appeal. When Vice President Richard M. Nixon met with Soviet premier Nikita Khrushchev at the American National Exhibition in Moscow, he trumpeted the virtues of the "free world" in front of a life-size model of an American ranch house. Their encounter became known as the "kitchen debate," carried out as it was before that cornucopia of consumer goods.[4]

The families enshrined in public culture did not, in the language of a later era, "look like America." Rather, they were almost uniformly of a single type: white, native-born, nuclear families with male breadwinners, usually living in the suburbs. These were the households featured in some of television's most popular offerings: *Leave It to Beaver, The Adventures of Ozzie and Harriet,* and *Father Knows Best.* In them, only men held jobs, white men held all the desirable ones, and the exceptions proved the rule. The few men of color who appeared in prime time were in character roles, such as Desi Arnaz, the light-skinned Cuban émigré entertainer, whose troubles with English supplied many of *I Love Lucy*'s laughs. The talented Nat King Cole for a time had his own television show, featuring some of the leading figures in contemporary music, until a station executive reprimanded the show's producer, saying, "Nat is a Negro and most of these musicians are white and it looks like the white guys are working for a Negro." Advertisers stayed away for fear of losing white consumers, and the show could not be sustained.[5]

As far as mass culture was concerned, others existed only to serve the white male breadwinner, his homemaker wife, and their dependent children. In these glory years of consumer capitalism, advertising regularly rehearsed these assumptions. Viewers could easily conclude that "all Negroes in America were servants or comic characters," wrote one critic in *Negro Digest.* With Aunt Jemima in her classic mammy attire as the archetypal black woman and Uncle Ben in his white butler jacket as the archetypal black man, "every ad [depicting African Americans] stamps upon the mind the menial, second-class 'place' of the Negro." In the world paraded before Americans, black men and women be-

longed only insofar as they advanced the comfort of whites. Otherwise, they suffered near absolute invisibility, as one contemporary survey attested: "Not a single advertisement which purported to depict a cross section of the public contained the figure of a Negro. In street scenes . . . in groups of workers, nowhere was a Negro to be found." Advertisers defended their work on the grounds that it portrayed their market: "typical Americans." Blacks were not typical Americans in the view of Hollywood producers, either. "The motion picture industry," as one leader of the NAACP put it, "still treats the Negro as an invisible man, as a menial, as an outworn stereotype."[6] The mass culture of the fifties appears almost cartoonish now, the popular films and television shows as much as the earnest advertisements.

Yet the images captured something important: the family wage system that shaped American social policy. That system built on a longstanding division of labor that assigned women responsibility for child rearing and men responsibility for income earning, exalting the male breadwinner as the provider for his dependent wife and children. First articulated as a goal by reformers in the 1800s, the family wage became a reality for growing numbers of households thanks to improved earnings spurred by unionization after the late 1930s. And yet, even at its mid-century peak, a large share of the population fell outside the system's net—not only widowed and single women, but also less-skilled workers in general and low-wage workers of color in particular.[7]

Believing male labor the norm and female labor an aberration, employers and policymakers constructed a labor market biased toward men, especially white men, and devised social welfare policy that shored up male-dominated households while weakening others. The family wage norm served as a grounding principle for the two-track welfare state built in the Progressive Era and the New Deal years. The superior, entitlement track of this system rewarded male wage earning through policies such as workmen's compensation, unemployment insurance, and Social Security. Its inferior, means- and morals-tested track grudgingly sustained women and children cut off from access to male wages through mothers' pensions, and later Aid to Families with Dependent Children. Well into the 1960s, the pecking order proved self-reinforcing, as the closing of good jobs to women, the lack of reproductive control, and the stigmas attached to divorce and homosexuality bolstered the male breadwinner system, while the exclusion of

most families of color from that norm ensured that black women would have to hold jobs throughout their lives.[8]

The partial character of the American welfare state reinforced the prominence of white men and the marginality of others. The New Deal had emerged from compromises that wrote inequality into its component policies, from labor standards and work relief to housing and Social Security. Determined to protect the South's racial hierarchy and low-wage regional economy from challenge, southern Democrats in Congress joined with conservative Republicans to exact their pound of flesh before agreeing to social legislation. As the price of passage, northern reformers had to accept the exclusion of farm and domestic workers from reform legislation and abide the denial of voting rights to blacks in the South. National Democratic leaders felt a need, as the NAACP put it, to "appease the traditional Southerners at the expense of America's Negro citizens."[9] Most white voters in the North, Democrats and Republicans alike, came to think of policies that privileged them and excluded blacks as fair entitlements.[10] With nearly all southern blacks unable to vote until 1965, this system proved all but impossible to fight on its home ground.

There, the long shadow of slavery continued to dim the prospects for Americans of color, denying them benefits that whites took for granted. Cotton, as a sharecropper organizer wrote in the depths of the Great Depression, "to a greater degree than any other product of industry or agriculture rules the South." It also dominated black life. More than two in three African Americans lived in that region in 1950. Trapped in an isolated, low-wage labor market and cut off from New Deal programs, some men still worked behind mules and plows. For their part, more than two out of every five black women in the labor force performed service in a private household, as excluded from the protection of labor law as those who worked the fields. "Negroes of the South have almost all the household jobs and nearly half of the laborer jobs," noted the economist Vivian Henderson in 1963. Only three in a hundred held clerical jobs.[11] In Atlanta, inquiring ministers found that "it is often necessary for Negro girls with one or more years of college training to work as maids. Negro men must take their college diplomas to the Post Office to work sorting mail."[12]

With the exception of tobacco factories and laundries, the same white managers who entrusted their children to black nannies balked at

allowing black laborers to work at their machines. Confining African Americans to the occupational ghetto of manual labor, southern whites built fortifications around more desirable jobs so as to "give preferential status to White employees."[13] When non-farm employers hired blacks, it was in a strictly limited capacity: as unskilled or janitorial workers, or occasionally as semiskilled laborers thanks to the efforts of industrial unions in the 1940s and 1950s. There was virtually no "direct interracial competition for jobs" beyond the most "dead-end, isolated work." Even within a single firm, most occupations were known as either "white jobs" or "Negro jobs," with no traffic in between. Blacks who tried to cross the line were rebuffed with the reminder that "this is white man's work." To be accused of "getting out of place" was to risk reprisal, as white vigilantes in the South often targeted those who had managed to achieve some kind of success.[14]

Although the particulars varied by state, sector, and firm, white managers used common methods to keep black workers subordinate. They restricted them to particular job categories with distinctive application forms and segregated lines of seniority, sometimes in collaboration with white workers and their unions. They segregated workplace facilities, too, providing white-only restrooms, lunch rooms, drinking fountains, coffeepots, telephones, even time clocks. As the National Urban League summarized the brutal irony nationwide, "Every labor, management and government device intended to put the right man in the right job or to protect the worker is used to keep out the Negro." One study of North Carolina, the state with the second-largest African American population in the country, found in industry after industry "a rigid pattern of job discrimination based on separate lines of progression, the limiting of all Negroes, however well qualified, to menial job classifications, and the denial of equal seniority rights."[15] Those whose task was to gauge merit were blind to it in blacks. "We do not have a chance of getting a job making a decent salary," Helen Clinton of North Carolina told a committee of inquiry. When responding to an ad for a woman with a high school education (she herself had two years of college), "I was told they wanted white women only." No matter "how much education you might have they won't give you a chance at a job," she said. "It makes you feel awful."[16]

In the North, the division of labor was less stark but still forbidding. Here, blacks had a better chance of securing semiskilled positions as

factory operatives, yet the skilled crafts, white-collar jobs in business, and professional positions with white-owned institutions remained largely out of reach. Airlines, for example, the very symbol of modernity, hired blacks for ground jobs only, never for in-flight work. Even in the most liberal locale in the nation, New York City, the racial division of labor in the workplace had long enjoyed the protection of law and custom and was still actively patrolled to keep good jobs a white monopoly.[17] The U.S. Labor Department's official *Dictionary of Occupational Titles* included racial slurs, leading a United Auto Workers union local in 1955 to protest the job title "niggerhead" as "a continuing insult to the millions of Negroes who are citizens of the United States."[18]

A small number of blacks managed to train for and secure better employment through determined effort and luck. In 1950, 2.2 percent of black men and 5.7 percent of black women worked as professionals. This feat was notable, yet the numbers were small, consisting largely of teachers of black children trained by historically black institutions. After graduation, African Americans found that they had to build their own analogues to the white-run professional associations that either refused them membership or kept them subordinate. By mid-century, black professionals had founded the National Bar Association, the National Medical Association, and the National Association of Colored Graduate Nurses, among others. Where African Americans enjoyed success in the business world, it was nearly always in black-owned firms.[19]

Once set in motion, the system of economic exclusion proved self-perpetuating. Parents who led hardscrabble lives and had little social power found it hard to push their children up the economic ladder, while an array of policies cut the ladder off just above its lowest rungs for most black climbers. A segregated educational system that grossly underfunded black schools was one such impediment. Where the slave South had made teaching blacks a criminal offense, the sharecropping South schooled its black labor force as little as possible. To protect planters from challenges and out-migration, southern communities usually spent a third to a half less on education than other regions of the country over the years 1890 to 1940.[20] Needing wages, and seeing no prospect of better jobs through continued schooling, most rural blacks stopped attending school early. In 1940, only 14 percent of black women and 11 percent of black men nationally had completed high

school, compared to 40 percent of whites.[21] While professional and clerical jobs were out of bounds, black young people were also denied access to vocational training for skilled blue-collar jobs, allowing employers to claim that black applicants lacked the necessary qualifications for the work.[22] In the North, housing segregation ensured school segregation at the same time that it kept blacks isolated from word-of-mouth information about better positions.[23]

Raised in a world so divided, most whites in the 1950s could not imagine an inclusive workplace, much less operate one. White "children's attitudes toward Negroes," the psychologist Kenneth Clark observed, "are determined chiefly not by contact with Negroes but by contact with the prevailing attitudes toward Negroes." The results were insidious. "The white child in a white milieu," as a group of educators later put it, "builds into his personality a feeling of the rightness of whiteness," a conviction "that whiteness, the way he is, is natural and standard."[24] That conviction infused the culture to the point where most whites could not see obstacles to black mobility that appear, in hindsight, sharp as razor wire.

Other Americans of color also faced obstacles that put the family wage ideal beyond their reach. Mexican Americans were by far the largest minority in the country after African Americans, numbering about 5 million in the southwestern United States in 1960. Mexicans first became part of the U.S. population after the war with Mexico in the 1840s, when American peace treaty negotiators gained for the United States half of its neighbors' country. Thereafter, most Mexican Americans remained in the Southwest, where, like blacks, they were cut off from the huge wave of industrialization that benefited southern and eastern European immigrants in the North in the early twentieth century. Whether native-born or immigrant, Mexican Americans lacked the rights of full citizens, a truth brutally enacted when over 400,000 suffered forced expulsion to Mexico during the Great Depression. Agricultural employers depended on people of Mexican descent as a landless migrant labor force that could be shifted about with little interference. Treated as inferiors by whites and subjected to discrimination, Mexican Americans were nevertheless better off than blacks in having access to many public accommodations closed to blacks by Jim Crow laws, and in being treated as a significant constituency by white public officials.[25]

In the economy defined by these overlapping boundaries, women were almost invariably relegated to the low-status jobs deemed suitable for their sex and race. Black women, those women most likely to be in the labor force, were confined mainly to service and menial blue-collar work at mid-century, with annual earnings half those of white women. Employed Latinas tended to work with their families in the fields, in low-paid factory jobs such as in canneries, or, for lucky second-generation women, in clerical jobs. White women fared better, but not nearly so well as their own brothers or husbands. At mid-century, nearly all women labored in low-level, sex-segregated occupations. When they did gain work as professionals, it was usually in fields that men scorned, such as elementary school teaching, nursing, and librarianship. And although the absolute number of women professionals was growing slowly, women's share of professional jobs had actually dropped since the turn of the century. Married women workers had become scapegoats for job losses in the Great Depression, as fierce attacks on their right to work produced large-scale firings and downgrading that left women who might have aspired to careers demoralized about their prospects.[26] As for graduate education, after a brief opening of doors induced by the shortage of men during World War II, some colleges and universities held down women's enrollment to make way for male veterans. By the 1950s, near-certain discrimination combined with cultural pressure to encourage women to focus instead on their families.[27]

What kept the whole system intact was employers' conviction that they could do as they wished with their own resources, a conviction backed by a legal system that defined the rules of the industrial order. Businessmen had allies beyond their own ranks to defend their understanding of freedom of contract, thanks to the nation's founding commitment to the rights of property—and to the popular success myth that led so many whites to imagine themselves or their relatives someday sitting in the boss's chair. One teacher, for example, argued against fair employment legislation as an injustice because it would violate the "freedom of hiring [that] has been a man's right since the rights of Man were recognized." If an employer "wants a white man, he has the right to have him, regardless of who applies with equal credentials." Similarly, a self-described "friend of the negro" declared, "I cannot subscribe to a doctrine which denies to anyone the right to reject a negro—or a white person either—if negroes—or whites—*are* objec-

tionable to him." Employers, he insisted, "have human rights which should be respected." To deny them full freedom of action, protested others, "savors of slavery"; it would be "socialistic tyranny."[28] This understanding of property rights as the core of liberty trumped claims to fair employment and equal access to jobs. The nation's courts, and most of its white citizens, agreed that American employers had, quite literally, "a right to discriminate."

YET THE APPEARANCE of stability within the culture of exclusion camouflaged a more complex reality. The supportive social order was weakening in the 1950s in ways that would increasingly invigorate struggles for inclusion in coming years. Political, economic, and social changes under way at the time enabled African American activists to demand inclusion as never before. Even "if he hasn't got the world in a jug," said Congressman Adam Clayton Powell, Jr., "the black man . . . has the stopper in his hand."[29]

In 1940, with World War II looming, A. Philip Randolph, the head of the leading black trade union in the United States, had conceived the first national mass movement against employment discrimination. Announcing to the nation, "We Loyal Colored American Citizens Demand the Right to Work and Fight for Our Country," organizers of the March on Washington movement vowed that ten thousand demonstrators would converge on the nation's capital to protest the use of Jim Crow factories and a Jim Crow military in a war against fascism. The movement won the nation's most active unions to its side when the Congress of Industrial Organizations (CIO) condemned job discrimination as a "direct attack against our nation's policy to build democracy in our fight against Hitlerism." Fearful that the unrest could disrupt military preparations, President Franklin Delano Roosevelt announced Executive Order 8802. The first presidential order to benefit blacks since Reconstruction, it outlawed discrimination by companies and unions engaged in war work on government contracts and created a mechanism to fight it: a federal Fair Employment Practice Committee. As the FEPC helped black workers enter good defense industry jobs, the experience taught a clear lesson: that progress would come from a combination of grassroots organizing and federal action against recalcitrant employers.[30]

The demands of mobilization against a fascist enemy opened all

kinds of long-standing prejudices to question and challenge. For the first time, immigrants from eastern and southern Europe came to feel recognized as full Americans. African Americans, too, found new leverage with which to argue for fair treatment. "Prove to us," Walter White of the NAACP challenged white America, "that you are not hypocrites when you say this is a war for freedom." Black activists waged what some dubbed the "Double V" campaign for victory over fascism abroad and racism at home. As the NAACP's monthly journal, *The Crisis*, urged its millions of readers in 1944, "The Dixie octopus strangling the rest of the country must be shaken off."[31]

In the vanguard of the postwar movement stood many black veterans who had sacrificed for "the free world" and now wanted to live in one. Some 500,000 African Americans had served in the military during the war. When they came home, studies found that four in five wanted to escape forever the kind of work they did before the war. They confronted roadblocks at every turn, starting with the Veterans Administration itself. Angry, many became active in the NAACP, the CIO, and other groups fighting for fairness. William A. Ashby, a longtime leader in the Newark, New Jersey, Urban League, described the feelings of thousands of his peers. "They said: 'I'm tired of all this goddam crap. Tired of hearing the white man say, 'I can't serve no niggers in my restaurant,' tired of being told, 'I ain't got no place for colored in my hotel.' Why, hell, I've been to Europe. Hitler leveled his bullets at me. Missed. I went to the Pacific. Mr. Hirohito sent his madmen at me to blow me to hell in their planes. I'm still here. Why don't I tell the white man, 'Take your goddam boots off my neck! Get the hell out of my road so I can pass! I know how to run around you or jump over you.'"[32]

Although white women and Mexican Americans also organized at mid-century, none pressed for economic inclusion as hard as African Americans did. More than others, black activists drew on long-held convictions to deny the legitimacy of the prevailing social hierarchy. In the antebellum era, African Americans who escaped the South and the abolitionists allied with them protested the starkest form of job segregation imaginable, that practiced by "the Slave Power." After emancipation left African Americans an overwhelmingly working-class people, many tried in various ways to gain better terms of employment. In the late nineteenth century, some fought to end a new form of unfree labor based on race, the convict lease system. Others looked to labor

unions to improve the jobs they already held. In coal mines and lumber camps, on docks and in laundries, black workers joined together—sometimes in rocky alliance with white workers—to make their jobs pay and to exercise more power.[33]

They were able to mobilize against exclusion as powerfully as they did during the war, owing to a series of profound changes in national life. The most important were those set in motion during the Great Depression, when the country embraced the principle of social citizenship. Along with basic civil and political rights, Americans won social rights, including public provision for common human needs such as old age security, to be guaranteed by the national government, as well as freedom from employer discrimination against union members. Without this prior commitment to the principle of social citizenship, government action to promote the inclusion of black workers would have been unthinkable, for it presupposed a federal right to intervene in businesses and to claim precedence over states in labor-related matters. Just as national New Deal programs helped bring increased parity in wages and working conditions north and south, so government might now be urged to bring convergence between whites and blacks. In an omen of the future, the number of African American federal workers tripled between the Hoover presidency and 1941 to reach 150,000; although most remained in the lowest grades, they still enjoyed more security than private-sector workers.[34]

In their appeals to the federal government, blacks found new allies in the labor movement—or, rather, that part of it forged in the crucible of the depression: the Congress of Industrial Organizations. Its organizers rejected the strategy of exclusionary and segregationist craft unionism that labor had pursued for half a century for a new vision of social unionism. They organized all workers in the nation's mass production industries, unskilled as well as skilled, believing that the security of any worker depended on the involvement of all. On this basis, organizers appealed to black workers as well as white, and by war's end had enrolled four out of every five manufacturing workers. By 1943, some 400,000 black workers had joined, backed by middle-class black leaders as well as white co-workers. CIO unions did not eliminate workplace discrimination, nor did most try. But they provided black workers with powerful tools to tackle it: collective bargaining as a means to compel employers to agree to union demands, seniority to prevent arbitrary

firings, grievance systems to appeal violations of workers' rights, and one of the country's most powerful lobbying bodies committed to economic justice and an expanded welfare state. "The CIO has brought more hope for progress to Negroes than any other social institution in the South," wrote the southern-born organizer Lucy Mason Randolph. "Of first significance to Negroes is the acknowledgment of themselves as persons entitled to democratic respect," an acknowledgment that opened the way to national belonging.[35]

The new conditions in turn strengthened black protest organizations as vehicles for economic inclusion as well as civil rights. The NAACP, founded in 1909, had long pursued a gradual strategy of changing the law that placated wealthy white donors while neglecting the pressing needs of its overwhelmingly working-class constituency. But facing criticism and competition from black radicals in the 1930s, the organization increasingly turned attention to the needs of black working people and allied with the CIO. So, too, did the once anti-union National Urban League, whose founding motto was "Not Alms But Opportunity." Calling for "jobs and justice," the League now advised black workers to "get into somebody's union and stay there." It worked with the NAACP, the National Negro Congress, and the National Council of Negro Women to expose discrimination in New Deal programs and push for universal social rights.[36] By the end of the decade, most black leaders came out boldly for an end to Jim Crow. "It is not a question of wanting to sit in the classroom with white students," the legal strategist Charles Houston made clear. "It is a question of vindicating one's citizenship." In 1942 these groups gained a new ally when radical Christian pacifists developed the Congress of Racial Equality (CORE). One founder was James Farmer, who had earned a bachelor of divinity degree at Howard University but abstained from ordination because "I didn't see how I could honestly preach the Gospel of Christ in a church that practiced discrimination." Devoted to direct action for justice, Farmer took from the CIO the idea of "sit-down strikes" and backed the nation's first sit-ins to end segregation in restaurants and workplaces.[37]

The Brotherhood of Sleeping Car Porters (BSCP), a significant force in black and national political life, illustrates the dynamics of social change at mid-century. Black railroad workers faced bitter discrimination in a division of labor so systematic that it later gained notice as

"one of the most highly institutionalized forms of industrial segregation in our land." But in a telling commentary on Jim Crow, the railroads' Pullman car porter jobs were highly desirable because they paid better than most jobs African American men could get; the tens of thousands who held them became an esteemed elite in a community where class divisions remained relatively shallow. After decades of organizing attempts, in the 1930s the porters won a union representation election, led by the brilliant A. Philip Randolph, the Florida-born grandson of slaves and son of a self-taught minister. Randolph had escaped the South as a teenager by laboring in the kitchen of a passenger ship bound for New York. There he worked day jobs while attending night school at City College, and joined the Socialist Party. A staunch advocate of unions, Randolph was recruited by Pullman porters to organize their trade. Backed by this well-organized, forward-looking constituency, Randolph for years led the fight for better jobs and full citizenship for black workers. Thanks to their unions, railroad men by mid-century might own their own homes and send their children to college.[38]

Beginning in the depression, African Americans drew attention to their desperation for jobs. In New York City, a study commissioned by the mayor to make sense of the Harlem riot of 1935 found that the source of the community's problems was that black workers were denied employment that paid a decent living. "The first and most fundamental problem of the Negro citizens of Harlem," the illustrious bi-racial panel concluded, "is the economic problem."[39] Addressing that problem, blacks not only in New York but also in other cities such as Chicago, Detroit, and Baltimore claimed new rights to jobs based on their standing as consumers. They organized against white employers in their communities who profited from the purchases of blacks but refused to employ them. Under the slogan "Don't Buy Where You Can't Work," they picketed offending businesses to demand the hiring of blacks in proportion to their presence in the area population.[40]

Working in local groups, labor, and government, black activists began to gain a wider hearing among progressive whites and stimulated them to doubt time-honored ways of thinking. More and more, American scholars were challenging the biological racism spread by nineteenth-century intellectuals. The Columbia University anthropologist Franz Boas led the way in the first decades of the century. Declaring that "culture makes man, not race," Boas and his colleagues put the

burden of proof on those who claimed that nonwhites lacked ability. Their research modeled a new relativism that demonstrated how environment shaped culture. In the 1930s they at last broke through the old orthodoxy in discipline after discipline, as their research in psychology, sociology, and history amplified the messages of scholar-activists such as W. E. B. DuBois, Louis Adamic, and Carey McWilliams. "Intellectual revolutions can rarely be dated with precision," writes one observer, "yet, clearly the attitudes of social scientists in the United States changed markedly" at this time.[41]

The new ways of thinking reached white readers with the 1944 publication of *An American Dilemma: The Negro Problem and Modern Democracy*. In this massive study funded by the Carnegie Corporation, the Swedish economist Gunnar Myrdal and his team of U.S. researchers concluded that the so-called "Negro problem" was really a problem of whites. "Though our study includes economic, social, and political race relations," they wrote, "at bottom our problem is the moral dilemma of the American" who extolled fairness in the abstract yet systematically denied it to African Americans. The U.S. Supreme Court, hearing lawsuits brought by African Americans, began in a string of decisions after 1938 to chip away at Jim Crow.[42]

As the New Deal enabled blacks to organize more successfully, it also gave them urgent reason to do so. By paying to reduce production, New Deal farm policy encouraged cotton planters to shed workers as well. And that undermined the sharecropping system that had sustained the exclusion of blacks from power for almost a century. Where once planters had tried to keep laborers tied to the land, restricting their education and their access to the wider world, now they expelled them and, in the World War II era, turned to machines instead. The proportion of black men employed in agriculture, forestry, and fisheries, 42.5 percent in 1939, plummeted to 12.5 percent by 1959 as mechanization plowed under the labor system that black disfranchisement had aimed to protect. Machines picked 5 percent of the nation's cotton in 1950; ten years later the figure was 50 percent, and 98 percent ten years after that. In the space of twenty years a whole social system was all but gone. Nearly 20 million people, black and white, left agrarian life in the 1940s and 1950s in "one of the largest and most rapid mass internal movements of people in history."[43]

Escaping the fields, rural blacks joined wage earners and profession-

als in cities and towns where organizing was possible with fewer life-threatening reprisals from white supremacist vigilantes. Urban black communities started to amass other resources needed for the battle against exclusion. Between 1930 and 1960, the percentage of black southerners living in urban areas almost doubled to 58 percent. City life offered better jobs and pay as well as more safety, and black incomes in the South, while still very low, improved from 1949 to 1962. As migrants used their greater security and resources to strengthen community institutions, church congregations gained members as well as confidence to speak out on racial injustice. Black colleges grew, too: between 1941 and 1964, the proportion of blacks who had completed college rose from less than 2 percent to over 5 percent. Black voter registration more than quadrupled between 1944 and 1950 to more than half a million, with virtually all the growth in southern cities. In the North and West, black voters acquired the numbers to decide some elections.[44] Together, these changes inspired growing numbers to organize for access to good jobs and the full belonging in the polity they implied.

For a few years after the war, the movement went from strength to strength. As membership in unions and the NAACP alike surged to unheard-of heights, labor and black groups often joined together to fight Jim Crow in workplaces, and sometimes in housing, schooling, and public accommodations. Led by left-wing African Americans in CIO unions, the movement in New York City fought to open good jobs, gain better housing and schools, end police brutality, help free peoples of color worldwide from colonial rule, and more. "It forged the modern urban Black political agenda," notes the historian Martha Biondi, "which included demands from criminal justice reform to affirmative action that would shape Black advocacy for the rest of the century." The vision went beyond civil rights per se to genuine equality in a more robust democracy.[45]

New Yorkers were not alone in this quest. Around the country, increasingly radical organizing for racial equality, backed by African Americans' new power in progressive labor unions, developed in places from Detroit and Los Angeles to Memphis, Tennessee, and Durham, North Carolina. In the South, NAACP membership quadrupled to over 400,000 in 1946, while northern-led black civil rights organizations worked in coalition with Jewish organizations such as the American Jewish Congress, the American Jewish Committee, and the Jewish Labor Committee to work for civil rights legislation that would benefit both groups.[46] By 1948 the movement was strong enough to make racial justice an issue in the U.S. presidential race and split the party of the once Solid South three ways. Running as the candidate of the breakaway Progressive Party, Henry Wallace called "the race problem . . . the South's and the nation's number one problem." As Harry Truman, in turn, struggled to keep black voters loyal to the Democratic Party, he ran on a platform committed to civil rights as never before—so much so that South Carolina's Strom Thurmond led a mutiny of Dixiecrats to form a new States' Rights Party. Short-lived as both third parties proved, the Democratic mainstream would never return to where it had been before; black voters mattered too much in key northern states.[47]

But the momentum soon came to an abrupt stop. As the United States and the Soviet Union clashed after the war, their conflict set off a "red scare" that devastated organizing for economic inclusion. The labor radicalism that had encouraged blacks and Hispanics to fight discrimination turned out to be vulnerable in the cold war because communists, black and white, were among its most passionate activists. As radicals came under attack from white authorities, liberal and social-democratic leaders also shunned them and pushed them out. The situation was complicated; many activists had understandable qualms about Stalinism and Communist Party tactics. But the toll was ruinous. "The leftists were the only ones who could mobilize white supporters to support a black picket and strikes of black workers," one Memphis labor activist later rued. "When they broke up the left coalition, then they began to lose the strikes." The left had also led in advancing black interests on the job. In the recession of 1949, for example, communists pressed hard to preserve the wartime foothold blacks had gained in industry. They argued that seniority should be suspended so as to keep blacks, the last hired, from being first fired. In the two left-led unions that also had a say in hiring, it was the leftists who ensured that one in every four workers placed in jobs was black, argued for work-sharing instead of layoffs, and pushed for what the then rank-and-filer David Montgomery described as "the automatic awarding of two to five years seniority to all Blacks, to compensate for the many decades in which they had been barred from employment in the industries altogether."

After radicals were driven from leadership, no one made such proposals for many years.[48]

By the late 1940s, anticommunism was crippling efforts at jobs and justice. Nationally, leaders of the CIO were terrified that resurgent Republicans in Congress would license an open shop drive like the one that followed World War I. Anxious to stave off a mortal threat as well as to solidify their own control, they clamped down on radicals. Driven by the anti-labor Taft-Hartley Act, passed in 1947, the CIO expelled eleven international unions in 1949 with over 1 million members, among them those that had fought hardest to change employer and union racism. With the CIO debilitated by the purge and drained by ongoing rivalry from the more conservative American Federation of Labor (AFL), and with conservative Republicans and southern Democrats dominating Congress, efforts to win a permanent FEPC came to naught. The NAACP had made this reform its "top legislative priority" in 1949, but the cold war doomed it. The alliance of southern Democrats and conservative Republicans using anticommunism to fight reform was simply too powerful.[49]

In the meantime, to be concerned with black rights was to be suspected of subversion in the eyes of ever more influential anticommunists in and out of government. When fair employment legislation was proposed for New York State in 1945, for example, the popular conservative columnist Westbrook Pegler insisted that "all such proposals . . . are the work of Communists and their kind[,] whose intent is not to open opportunities for Negroes but to cause friction and provoke disorder by creating intolerable personal situations." Within a few years, such thinking had infected the mainstream. "Of course," said the chair of a loyalty review panel in the postal service, "the fact that a person believes in racial equality doesn't *prove* that he's a Communist, but it certainly makes you look twice, doesn't it? You can't get away from the fact that racial equality is part of the Communist line." "Anything that benefited Black people at the time," a woman then doing union organizing explained, "was labeled by our government as red, as communist." Southern segregationists developed a particularly extreme and long-lived anticommunism to paralyze organizing and immunize white supremacy from democratic challenge.[50]

Like the CIO, the NAACP purged its ranks to appease the attackers and ensure national leaders' control. It disbanded branches and dispensed with members who seemed risky—even its founder, the towering intellectual W. E. B. DuBois. Some branches grew so nervous that they refused to accept white members for fear they might be leftists. This menacing climate yielded a weaker and more cautious civil rights movement in the early 1950s, one fearful of direct action, mass politics, or economic demands that might draw the ire of red-baiting critics. In New York City, the epicenter of African American organizing, anticommunism ravaged the cause. Nearly all those involved "suffered persecution, investigation, repression, or censorship." Most historians now concur that, as one put it, "anticommunism proved invaluable to white supremacists during the 1940s and 1950s."[51]

Setting back racial equality in many areas, the red scare especially hurt the quest for jobs and justice. It enabled northern business interests, represented by conservative Republicans, and southern white supremacists, represented by the Democratic Party, to block expansion of the New Deal to groups denied its benefits, such as agricultural and domestic service workers, and to prevent the expansion of social citizenship to new areas such as the provision of health care. As the very idea of economic equality became suspect, resurgent corporate political power brought renewed popular white support for private property rights over human rights. The years from 1948 to the early 1960s witnessed a revival of corporate sway over public affairs to a degree not seen since the Gilded Age.[52] With renewed business hegemony, momentum for government-backed equal job rights practically dissolved.

In the name of true Americanism, the National Association of Manufacturers (NAM) and the U.S. Chamber of Commerce fought any interference with managerial autonomy. Eager to reclaim authority and prerogatives lost in the depression years, those leading business associations were determined to make sure that the federal government did not gain any new powers, such as the responsibility to enforce equal opportunity. NAM warned that laws prohibiting employment discrimination would "overemphasize differences among peoples" and so "might aggravate—rather than eliminate—antagonism and strife." By 1952, anticommunism had turned the tide, as the Republican Party gained control of both houses of Congress and put General Dwight Eisenhower in the White House. "For the first time in twenty years," notes one scholar, "friends of business dominated government in Washington."[53]

Just as the new conservative ethos suppressed challenges to the racial hierarchy, so too did it shore up restrictive gender roles. Mixing older notions that a woman's primary obligation was to her husband and children with a crude Freudian emphasis on biology as destiny, the new ideology assigned women the job of serving their work-weary spouses and attention-seeking children. The focus on family "togetherness" and the emphasis on service to men and children took aim at the autonomy many American women had developed in wartime jobs and experiences. "Women Aren't Men," chided a popular 1950 magazine article, as it summed up the new imperative: "It is for woman as mother, actual or vicarious, to restore security in our insecure world." In private as in public life, the credo of opinion makers was "containment."[54]

So enveloping was the racially specific family norm in postwar culture that it blinded even liberal whites. Social commentators who wrote searching critiques of American society in these years had trouble including African Americans in their thinking. Cut off by segregation from the deepest well of dissatisfaction in their society, white intellectuals found it easy to believe, as Seymour Martin Lipset sunnily declared, that "the fundamental problems of the industrial revolution have been solved." Even sociologists who made their living studying race relations failed to grasp the depth of black discontent, let alone to imagine the mass movement that was about to shatter the manufactured calm of the era. When white liberal intellectuals commented on the black experience or civil rights in the early 1950s, it was to promote what the black journalist Carl Rowan called a "cult of moderation."[55]

What most troubled even radical white critics in these years was not the exclusion of others but the archetypal white man's loss of independence and self-direction—his "conformity." Willy Loman, the tragic hero created by Arthur Miller in his Pulitzer Prize–winning play *Death of a Salesman*, was the quintessential example. Loman held a job to which few blacks had access and lived in a suburban community that would not have allowed them to buy homes, yet he was to stand as the American Everyman. Paul Goodman, author of the irreverent *Growing Up Absurd*, which would become a manifesto for later student activists, skewered the inanity of much adult life in contemporary America. Yet he understood the challenges of work and identity as a problem confronting young white males alone. Faced with a meaningless post as vice president of a company, "an idealistic young fellow would not want

to be such a man," Goodman declared. "It's hard to grow up when there isn't enough man's work." The 30 percent of Americans "who are still ill fed and ill housed and more outcast than ever" escaped his notice as actors whose concerns about work, meaningful or otherwise, counted. They appeared, instead, as the "them" for whom "we" could do more. The *One-Dimensional Man* of Herbert Marcuse's influential treatise was likewise assumed to be white and male; the ways in which others might experience the constraints or promises of modern life went unexplored. In C. Wright Mills's brilliant explorations of the new middle class and the "power elite" in postwar America, race was not a category of analysis. Exclusion was taken for granted.[56] Looking north from the South in the 1950s, the view was bleak indeed. "We have such a feeling here," the white progressive Virginia Durr wrote from Alabama, "that we have been abandoned by the rest of the country and by the government and left to the tender mercies of the Ku Klux Klan."[57]

In fact, few white Americans in any walk of life anticipated the challenge that was coming. In 1954 the U.S. Supreme Court shook them from their complacency when it overthrew federal support of black exclusion that went back to the *Plessy v. Ferguson* decision of 1896. Ruling unanimously in *Brown v. Board of Education*, the justices decreed segregation in education a denial of equal constitutional rights. They built their ruling on the legal precedents that NAACP attorneys such as Charles Houston and Thurgood Marshall had amassed in case after case since 1938. Once the high court reconciled itself to the New Deal, it agreed with them that political party primary elections that excluded blacks, segregation on interstate transportation, and inferior Jim Crow graduate and professional education violated the Constitution, and that railroad unions with state-granted exclusive bargaining power owed black members a "duty of fair representation."[58]

A pivotal victory, the *Brown* decision showed how the sword of the cold war might be made to cut two ways. As much as anticommunism had hurt grassroots organizing for inclusion, it also gave the cause unprecedented leverage. As international rivalry shifted from Europe to the nonaligned nations of Asia, Africa, and Latin America in the 1950s, U.S. leaders sought to counter Soviet claims of American racism in order to win support. Harry Truman put the imperative in his own curt way: "The top dog in a world which is 90 percent colored ought to clean his own house." The government's *amicus* brief in *Brown* commu-

nicated this recognition to the Court: "It is in the context of the present world struggle between freedom and tyranny that the problem of race discrimination must be viewed." Taking advantage of the opening created by the high court's decision and building on the social changes at mid-century, civil rights seekers rallied. "The magnitude of the decision shocked me," the black scholar Horace Cayton remarked. "A large hole had opened in the dike of segregation, and through it would soon pour a torrent."[59]

~ 2

The Fight Begins

In 1955, two insurgent movements broke through the superficial calm. Both claimed to represent the best of the American tradition, but what they valued differed starkly. Each embraced half of the divided heart of a nation pledged to liberty and justice for all, yet founded on slavery and unequal citizenship. African American activists struggling for inclusion stressed the promise of equality, opportunity, and fair reward for earned achievement. White conservatives, aiming to fend off change, stressed the traditions of economic liberty, small government, and privileged access for a minority. Gaining courage from the social developments altering the ground of politics, and confident that the Declaration of Independence represented the true soul of America, the black freedom movement revived from its cold war wounds and, with the Montgomery, Alabama, bus boycott, reestablished civil rights as a mass movement. Over the next decade, the demand for access to better employment would become an ever more vital part of the civil rights movement's grassroots and national efforts. Linking jobs to justice in creative ways immune from the red-baiting that destroyed earlier campaigns, participants built a broad coalition for reform.

Activists proposed a radical departure from the culture of exclusion, yet one anchored in values at the core of American political culture. After Montgomery, an ever-growing minority of African Americans